

Bank of Leeds Strategic Tourism Infrastructure Proposal

Bolton Abbey Railway Reopening & Yorkshire Dales Visitor Railway

A Seasonal Heritage Railway Investment Programme to Unlock Rural Tourism Growth

Prepared for:

Bank of Leeds – Tourism, Heritage & Regional Development Division

Investment Classification:

Heritage Infrastructure / Rural Tourism / Seasonal Transport / Hospitality Development

Proposed Financing Vehicle:

Bolton Abbey Railway Tourism Development Bond

Indicative Investment Requirement:

£75–100 million

Investment Horizon:

20 years

Executive Summary

The Bank of Leeds proposes a strategic investment programme to reopen and enhance the historic railway route connecting **Skipton – Embsay – Bolton Abbey – Addingham – Ilkley** as a dedicated tourist railway and seasonal visitor attraction.

The objective is not to recreate a commuter railway, but to establish:

"Yorkshire's premier scenic heritage railway experience — connecting visitors directly into the Yorkshire Dales landscape."

The original Midland Railway route opened in 1888, connecting Ilkley, Addingham, Bolton Abbey, Embsay and Skipton. Passenger services ceased in the 1960s, but part of the route survives today through the Embsay & Bolton Abbey Steam Railway heritage operation.

The proposal would expand the existing heritage railway into a commercially sustainable tourism asset operating primarily:

- April–October summer season,
- Christmas markets,
- autumn foliage specials,
- winter dining experiences.

The project would create a Yorkshire equivalent of:

- North Yorkshire Moors Railway,
- Jacobite Steam Train experience in Scotland,
- Swiss scenic mountain railways.

The investment thesis:

A relatively modest railway restoration investment could unlock hundreds of millions of pounds of tourism spending in the Yorkshire Dales.

1. Strategic Vision

The Yorkshire Dales Heritage Railway

A destination railway connecting:

Leeds
|
Ilkley
|
Addingham
|
Bolton Abbey
|
Embsay
|
Skipton
|
Yorkshire Dales

Future Visitor Experience

A visitor arrives at Ilkley or Skipton.

They board:

The Bolton Abbey Express

A heritage steam train travelling through:

- Wharfedale countryside,

- historic villages,
- Dales scenery.

Passengers experience:

- afternoon tea,
 - dining,
 - walking routes,
 - local food,
 - heritage attractions.
-

2. Why Bolton Abbey?

Bolton Abbey has a unique tourism proposition:

- historic abbey ruins,
- River Wharfe scenery,
- Yorkshire Dales landscape,
- walking tourism,
- affluent surrounding communities.

The railway historically supported tourism growth in Wharfedale; Ilkley's development as a Victorian visitor destination was strongly linked to railway access, with the original line reaching Bolton Abbey in 1888.

3. Current Asset Base

The existing heritage railway already demonstrates demand.

The Embsay & Bolton Abbey Steam Railway:

- operates on part of the former Midland Railway route,
- preserves historic railway infrastructure,
- attracts significant tourism interest.

Local planning documents have also recognised that extending heritage railway operations towards Skipton could contribute significantly to tourism growth at Skipton, Embsay and Bolton Abbey.

4. Proposed Investment Programme

Total Investment

£100 million

Component	Investment
Track restoration	£35m
Stations	£10m
Heritage rolling stock	£25m
Luxury carriages	£15m
Visitor facilities	£10m
Marketing platform	£5m

5. Railway Restoration Plan

Phase One: Embsay–Bolton Abbey Upgrade

Cost: £20m

Upgrade:

- track,
- signalling,
- bridges,
- stations.

Objective:

Increase reliability and frequency.

Phase Two: Bolton Abbey–Addingham Extension

Cost: £35m

Restore approximately the former railway corridor where practical.

The former route between Bolton Abbey and Addingham largely remains identifiable, although sections would require engineering assessment and restoration.

Works:

- track reinstatement,
- bridge works,

- drainage,
 - signalling.
-

Phase Three: Skipton / Ilkley Connectivity

Cost: £20m

Create visitor interchange connections.

Potential:

- heritage trains from Skipton,
 - tourist packages from Leeds/Bradford.
-

6. Rolling Stock Investment

£25 million

Create:

The Yorkshire Dales Collection

Steam Locomotives

Investment:

£8m

Includes:

- restoration,
 - leasing,
 - maintenance.
-

Heritage Carriages

Investment:

£12m

Modernised interiors:

- heating,
- comfortable seating,

- dining facilities.
-

Luxury Dining Carriages

Investment:

£5m

Product:

The Bolton Abbey Pullman

Ticket:

£175–250 per person

Includes:

- steam journey,
 - Yorkshire produce,
 - afternoon tea.
-

7. Tourism Business Model

Operating Season

Main:

April–October

Special:

- Christmas trains,
 - winter dining,
 - autumn weekends.
-

Visitor Forecast

Current heritage railway model:

approximately 100,000+ annual visitors.

Target after reopening:

500,000 visitors annually

Revenue Model

Standard Tickets

350,000 visitors

Average ticket:

£35

Revenue:

£12.25m

Premium Dining

75,000 passengers

Average spend:

£175

Revenue:

£13.1m

Events

- weddings,
- corporate hire,
- Christmas markets.

Revenue:

£5m

Retail & Food

Station villages:

Revenue:

£7m

Partnerships

Hotels:

Walking packages:

Dales tours:

Revenue:

£3m

Total Annual Revenue

£40 million

Operating Costs

Estimated:

£22 million/year

Includes:

- staff,
 - maintenance,
 - fuel,
 - insurance,
 - hospitality.
-

EBITDA Potential

£18 million/year

8. Economic Impact

Direct Employment

Rail operations:

150 jobs

Hospitality:

150 jobs

Retail:

100 jobs

Events:

50 jobs

Total Permanent Employment

450+ jobs

Construction Employment

10-year programme:

5,000 job-years

Regional Economic Impact

Tourism multiplier:

Every visitor spending on:

- accommodation,
- pubs,
- restaurants,

- shops,
- attractions.

Potential additional spending:

£75–100 million annually

9. Bank of Leeds Financing Model

Bolton Abbey Railway Tourism Bond

Initial Issue:

£75 million

Bond Term:

30 years

Security:

Backed by:

- ticket revenues,
 - commercial leases,
 - hospitality assets,
 - tourism facilities.
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Funding Structure

Source	Amount
Bank of Leeds	£50m
Tourism investors	£20m
Local partnerships	£10m
Heritage grants	£20m

10. Strategic Benefits

A. Yorkshire Tourism Growth

Creates a new flagship attraction.

B. Rural Economic Development

Supports:

- farms,
 - pubs,
 - hotels,
 - walking tourism.
-

C. Sustainable Tourism

Moves visitors by rail rather than cars.

D. Yorkshire Branding

Creates a globally marketable product:

"Steam through the Yorkshire Dales."

11. International Tourism Opportunity

Target markets:

United States

Demand for:

- steam railways,
 - British heritage,
 - countryside experiences.
-

Japan

Strong interest in:

- railway culture,
 - scenic journeys.
-

Europe

Weekend heritage tourism.

12. Risks

Engineering Costs

Mitigation:

- phased reopening,
 - prioritise tourist sections.
-

Seasonal Demand

Mitigation:

Create:

- Christmas markets,
 - dining trains,
 - events.
-

Volunteer Dependency

Mitigation:

Transition to:

- professional management,
 - paid tourism workforce.
-

13. Delivery Timeline

Phase 1 (2026–2030)

£30m

- infrastructure improvements,

- rolling stock,
 - expanded timetable.
-

Phase 2 (2030–2038)

£50m

- Addingham extension,
 - luxury services,
 - visitor facilities.
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Phase 3 (2038–2045)

£20m

- international marketing,
 - full tourism ecosystem.
-

Final Recommendation

The Bank of Leeds should establish:

Bolton Abbey Railway Development Corporation

with:

£100 million investment capacity

to restore the railway as a major Yorkshire tourism asset.

Final Investment Thesis

The original railway brought Victorian visitors into Wharfedale.

A modern reopening would do the same for a new generation.

The opportunity is not simply to restore old tracks.

It is to create:

"Yorkshire's premier heritage journey — a summer railway experience linking Britain's industrial past with its future tourism economy."

A Bank of Leeds-backed Bolton Abbey Railway could become one of Yorkshire's most recognisable tourism assets while generating long-term rural economic growth.